47TH ANNIVERSARY

THE BEST OF INDIA

INDIAN WRITING IN ENGLISH

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INGLISH LIKE US

From maverick madness to sanity and from magical realism to patient scrutiny, these books own the shelves they stand on

This is a terrible task. It might even have been possible 25 years ago, but at this point in time, you simply don't know what to do. So you fall back on galloping through the books you have kept over 40 years of book collecting to see which ones would still make the list and seeing what still seems to hold. Does this mean this is a personal list? You bet your deckle edge. Reading is an intensely personal habit. Reviewing comes from that same space, the personal masquerading as the hyperrational. This list is an invitation to you: go make your list. But do not do this on memory. It is a fickle thing memory and will not serve to help much. You have changed, the book has remained the same. (Or has it?) Something that rejoiced your heart may now seem a bit banal. And other books may take on a new glow. Every Best of...list should therefore be considered as a catalyst for another. Happy reacting.

Final caveat: I think sometimes I have chosen a book for a voice. The voice is a promise. The book is one of the parts that the voice has sung for us in the opera of the mind. I won't say which ones are books and which ones are voices, but you might be able to guess.

1. G.V. Desani

All About H. Hatterr (1948)

Oh my hat and whiskey, what a start we made. Shandy, I am saying, my buddies and biddies and biddas and other bodies. This was language retrofitted for the great new world of *Inglis ispikking*. It was a magnificent novel, and should have beaten the path straight, but its very audacity meant it ended up in a cul de sac and we had to wait for several years before we could do it again.

2. Salman Rushdie

Midnight's Children (1981)

When we did it again, how we did it! Salman Rushdie's Booker of Bookers, his Saleem Sinai, his intimacy and his expansiveness, his net slung wide across our history but also its fine appreciation of the miniature and the minuscule. Here it was, the magical realism and the metaphors: silence for a day unravelling the universe of the inside. Here it was pop culture references: babies switched at birth so that the *raja* becomes the *runk* and

TOP 10 INDIAN NOVELS IN ENGLISH

1. **G.V. Desani** *All About H. Hatterr (1948)*
2. **Salman Rushdie** *Midnight's Children (1981)*
3. **Amitav Ghosh** *The Hungry Tide (2004)*
4. **Kiran Nagarkar** *Cuckold (1997)*
5. **Manju Kapur** *Home (2006)*
6. **Anita Desai** *In Custody (1984)*
7. **Arundhati Roy** *The God of Small Things (1997)*
8. **Githa Hariharan** *When Dreams Travel (1999)*
9. **Amruta Patil** *Kari (2008)*
10. **I. Allan Sealy** *The Everest Hotel (1988)*